articles of association, this time was required for the consideration of a proposal for a change in the Chairman'.

'Chandra stood his ground and refused to be browbeaten,' says Singh. He replied that the Trusts had already got legal opinion from eminent jurists, confirming that such a notice was not required. Mistry quickly grasped the fact that legal opinion had been obtained and said agitatedly, 'I'm not privy to the legal opinion received by the Trusts and would like to have a copy of it.'

Chandra responded, 'You will have it,' but declined to specify any timeline. It was a stalemate. Ratan sat quietly, betraying no emotion. Since there was no desirable outcome from the informal discussions, Chandra proposed the name of Vijay Singh as the chair, which was seconded by Srinivasan. And as items related to Mistry would be coming up for consideration, Mistry was requested to recuse himself.

After taking over as the interim chairman, Singh proposed the taking up of additional items. The item first considered was the removal of Mistry from the post of chairman, Tata Sons, and various board committees; followed by increasing the age criterion for the retirement of directors; the reconstitution of the Nomination and Remuneration Committee with Sen, Piramal and Khambata, Singh and Srinivasan; and finally the appointment of Ratan as additional director and electing him as the interim chairman till a new chairman was selected.

The resolution to replace Mistry was proposed by Nohria and seconded by Piramal. Six of the eight-member board voted for the motion. Those in favour included the three Trusts nominees, Singh, Chandra and Nohria, and independent directors Piramal, Sen and Srinivasan. Hussain and Khambata, appointed to the board in 2013 and 2015 respectively by Mistry, abstained. And Mistry of course objected to the motion.

Hussain clarifies that he abstained as he was not informed about the reasons for the resolution to remove Mistry in advance of the board meeting. Besides, he says that he was not in favour of removing Mistry so early in his job. 'If you put him on the job, it was too early to take the call. Give him some more time,' he says.

No detailed reasons were, however, given for Mistry's removal as advised by the Trusts' legal advisers. They had advised that no useful purpose would be served by giving Mistry the reasons for his removal. If